

AI WEB DESIGN · THE BASICS

*Free
Guide*

Build Premium Sites with AI.

An open primer on using AI to build beautiful sites in an afternoon — the order, the tools, the moves. Made for anyone, no code background needed.

– Luke

If Claude is brand new for you, **read this first.**

This guide assumes you've already opened Claude once or twice. If that's still new, two minutes here and you're caught up. Skip ahead if you're already shipping.

What Claude is

Claude is an AI assistant made by Anthropic. **One app, one window, everything inside.** A chat where you talk to it. Files it can read and write for you. A live preview that opens any site it builds. Tools that run in the background. You never have to leave it.

Download at claude.com/download — free account, Mac or Windows.

What you actually need to know

You don't need to write code. You don't need a terminal. You don't need to know what a file extension is. You only need to be able to:

- **Open Claude** and start a new chat.
- **Type a sentence** — *"Build me a landing page for a coffee brand."*
- **Read what comes back** — Claude builds the site and opens the preview right there in the same window. If something's off, you say *"make the headline bigger"* and it updates live.

That's the whole prerequisite.

Talk to Claude like you'd talk to a smart friend who can also build.

One small thing before you start

The folder you downloaded with this PDF includes a small file called `CLAUDE.md`. It's **already filled in** — you don't need to edit anything. Just keep both files in the **same folder**, then open that folder in Claude. You only do this once.

what's a CLAUDE.md?

think of it as a short note you leave for Claude in your project folder — "when you build sites here, lean toward premium: motion-first, clean typography, no template feel." Claude reads it automatically when you open the folder.

What you're holding

Not a swipe file. Not 12 prompts to copy.

It's the actual order I follow when I sit down to build a site. Same 5 steps every time. The boring kind of consistency that makes the work look effortless from outside.

Read it once. Save it somewhere you'll actually find it. Open it next time you're staring at a blank screen with no idea what to do.

One afternoon from now, you'll have a real site. Reference folder picked, tools installed, hero visual generated, layout shipped, polished components dropped in. That's it. No course to finish, no community to join.

Who this is for

You don't need to write code. You need to read English and be willing to type more than 3 words at a time when you talk to an AI.

If you've ever opened a website and thought *"why does this feel expensive and mine doesn't"*, you're in the right place.

One thing before we start

I use every tool below. Most weeks. Some are free. Some cost a bit. When there's a way to skip a middleman and pay 2× less for the same thing, I'll tell you which middleman to skip. No affiliate links anywhere in here. Just the stack.

Let's go.

Phase 1 — Reference

"You can't build premium if you start from a blank screen."

What this phase does

Before you open any tool, you need a folder of sites and images that look the way you want yours to look. Not 50 references. **5 to 8 strong ones.**

This is the most-skipped step. Most people open Claude cold and try to "design from scratch." The result is generic. AI-generic. The kind of site that looks like every other landing page from 2024.

The fix is simple: spend 20 minutes collecting reference before you build anything.

*most skip
this step
↑*

Why most people skip it

It feels unproductive. You're not "making" anything. But this 20 minutes is the difference between a site that looks like AI made it and one that looks like **a human with taste did.**

WHAT YOU'LL NEED BEFORE STARTING

- A free Pinterest account.
- A folder name. Keep it simple. Example: `coffee-brand`.
- 20 minutes uninterrupted.

The steps

Each site has a **precise role**. Don't browse them randomly — go in this order, with this intent.

1. **Pinterest** — *the wide net*. Search the **vibe**, not "website design". Try "editorial hero typography", "vintage soda packaging", "3D card landing". Pin 6 to 8 images that all share something — color tone, type, energy. If the board looks chaotic, you haven't picked a direction yet. Keep filtering. pinterest.com
2. **Behance** — *the brand system*. Search the same vibe keywords. Save 1-2 design concept projects that show the **full brand**: palette extracted, typography rules, asset system, logo construction. These are your references for everything that lives around the site — cards, packaging, social, identity. behance.net
3. **MotionSites** — *the hero hook*. Save 2-3 sites whose **opening visual or first 5 seconds** would land your audience. This is where you steal the impact: a video hero, a parallax reveal, an entrance animation. motionsites.ai
4. **Dribbble** — *the structure + spare parts*. Save 1-2 shots that show **full layout structures** for the kind of site you're building (long-form scroll, dashboard, product page). Then save 1-2 more for micro-details: a button hover, a footer pattern, a form transition. dribbble.com

End of phase: 5 to 8 reference assets in your folder, each one with a known job — mood, brand system, hero impact, structure, micro-detail.

tip

don't pick references at random. decide in one sentence what you're going for ("a calm coffee shop with a vintage feel") and only save things that match. references that contradict each other confuse Claude later.

Phase 2 — Setup

What this phase does

You install the AI app you'll use to actually build the site, plus a few "**skills**" that teach it good design habits before you even start typing.

*one-time
only ↑*

This is a **one-time setup**. After today, you skip straight to Phase 3.

Why this matters

Plain Claude is smart but doesn't have strong opinions about design. The skills below give it opinions. They're free, they install in seconds, and they turn the difference between a website that's *correct* and one that looks **premium**.

WHAT YOU'LL NEED BEFORE STARTING

- A computer (Mac or Windows, both work).
- A free Anthropic account (claude.com).
- 30 minutes one time.

The steps

1. Download Claude desktop at claude.com/download. Install. Sign in with your free account. Works on Mac and Windows.
2. Open the **Plugin Marketplace** from inside Claude (you'll find it in the sidebar / settings). This is where Claude gets "*skills*" — extra knowledge that makes it better at specific things.
3. Install these 4 design skills — search each name in the marketplace and click install:
 - **UI-UX Pro Max** — 50+ styles, 161 palettes, 161 product types.
[Biggest single upgrade.](#)
 - **Frontend Design** — Anthropic's official, production-grade components.
 - **Theme Factory** — 10 prebuilt themes for landings, dashboards, slides.
 - **Webapp Testing** — lets Claude open your site in a real browser for mobile checks.
4. Add **Motion** the first time you build a site. Just type in chat: "*add motion as a dependency to this project.*" Motion is the animation library Claude reaches for whenever you ask for movement. One sentence, done.

tip

don't install 30 skills on day one. each one slightly biases how Claude responds. start with the 4 above, build 2 sites, then add more based on what you actually missed.

Phase 3 — Visuals + Motion

"The hero image is half the site. Generate it yourself, in your style, for free."

What this phase does

You make the **hero image** (the big visual at the top) yourself, with AI. Then you turn that image into a **5-second loop** so the page actually moves when someone lands on it.

Most workflow guides push you straight to Higgsfield or Runway here.

\$30 a month, "all in one." I'm telling you to skip them.

Why those tools are overpriced

They're wrappers. The image generator inside Higgsfield is the same Nano Banana 2 you can hit for free at Google AI Studio. The video generator is one of three open models they license, with a markup on top.

You pay for the dashboard. Not for the output.

If you can click between two browser tabs without crying, you save **\$20 to \$40 a month** and get exactly the same files at the source. Sometimes higher resolution, since the source doesn't compress them as aggressively.

*save \$40/mo
← right here*

WHAT YOU'LL NEED BEFORE STARTING

- A free Google account (aistudio.google.com sign-in).
- A Kling AI account (klingai.com) with a starter credit pack (\$5-10 covers a lot).

The steps

1. Open Google AI Studio at aistudio.google.com. Sign in. In the model dropdown, pick Nano Banana 2 (the latest image generator, formally called Imagen). On the **right-side panel**, set the **aspect ratio** you need (16:9 for hero, 1:1 for square, 9:16 for vertical) and bump **resolution to 4K**. Free tier covers plenty.
2. Let Claude write the prompt for you. Don't try to write the perfect visual prompt yourself — Claude is better at it. Open Claude, describe what you want in one casual sentence, and ask it to turn that into a full prompt.

you → claude

Write me a Nano Banana 2 prompt to generate a hero image for a website. I'll give you the brief in one line. Output a structured prompt with subject, lighting, mood, composition, aspect ratio 16:9, cinematic feel.

a perfume bottle floating mid-air with a soft blurred background

Claude returns a full structured prompt. **Copy. Paste into Google AI Studio.** Generate 3-4 variations. Pick your favorite. Download highest resolution.

3. **Animate the image.** Same trick — Claude writes the motion prompt for you. Open Kling AI at klingai.com and upload your image. Two paths depending on what you want:

For a subtle loop (background motion, atmospheric feel) — ask Claude:

you → claude

Write me a Kling Image-to-Video prompt for this hero. I want a slow camera push-in, 5 seconds, looped. ONE motion only.

Paste into Kling. Multiple motions in a single prompt confuse the model. Make it loop. Generate. Download MP4.

For something more articulate (a scene morph, a transformation between two distinct frames) — generate a second image as your end frame, then use Kling's "*Image-to-Video with End Frame*" to interpolate between the two. Claude stitches the resulting clips together inside your project — no external editor needed.

4. **Convert MP4 to GIF** or to a looped video file using ezgif.com (free). Compress to under 2MB so it loads fast on mobile.
5. **Save the file** in your project folder as `hero-video.mp4` or `hero.gif`. Phase 4 tells Claude to embed it.

Phase 4 — Build

"Three rounds. Structure first. Motion second. Polish last. Don't try to nail it in one shot."

What this phase does

You open Claude and have an actual conversation that produces a working website. Not one giant prompt that does everything. **Three focused rounds**, each fixing what the previous one didn't get right.

*3 rounds,
not 1 ↑*

Why most people get bad results

They try to write one huge prompt that says *"build me a beautiful hero with motion and a contact form and a footer and make it premium."* Claude tries to do everything at once and does each part badly.

Three smaller rounds gives Claude a chance to get the bones right before you ask for fancy details.

WHAT YOU'LL NEED BEFORE STARTING

- Your reference folder from Phase 1.
- Your hero video file from Phase 3.
- 90 to 120 minutes of focused time.

The steps (3 rounds)

Three rounds — but the order is **more flexible than it looks**. Sometimes the visual you made in Phase 3 is strong enough that the whole site should be built *around it* — letting it shape the tone, the typography, even the section choices. When that's the case, share the image with Claude before you do anything else.

- 1. Round 1 — structure.** Open Claude, start a new project, and ask it to build the page structure: which sections, in what order, with what kind of typography.
No animations yet, no fancy details. If your hero visual is the centerpiece of the brand, share it now and tell Claude to design the layout to match its tone. Otherwise, ask it to leave a placeholder where the hero video will go in round 2. Claude opens the preview in the same window — check the layout makes sense.
- 2. Round 2 — motion.** Tell Claude to embed the video file you made in Phase 3 as a full-screen looping background in the hero. Then ask for subtle fade-ins on text as the user scrolls. Remind Claude to use **Motion** (the small animation library you installed in Phase 2) — otherwise it might reach for a bigger one you don't have. The preview refreshes. Scroll through. The site should now feel alive.
- 3. Round 3 — polish.** Two parts here. First: open your reference folder from Phase 1 and pick 2-3 micro-details you want to steal (a button hover glow, tighter letter spacing on headlines, a faded line between sections). Send them all in one message. Then: **fine-tune the motion**. If the hero feels too fast, the scroll too jerky, or a transition is off, just say so — Claude will slow it down, smooth the easing, soften the timing.

When Claude gets it wrong

It will. Round 1 or round 2, something won't work. Normal. The fix is one sentence: describe what's broken, then describe what you want instead. Example: *"the hero text is hard to read against the video, add a 30% dark overlay between them so the headline pops."* Done in seconds.

Don't start over. Don't restart the project. Just keep talking.

tip

if round 3 breaks something that worked in round 2, ask: "show me what changed in the last edit." Claude lists the diff. then revert just the broken bit instead of nuking everything.

Phase 5 — Components

"Don't reinvent the form, the marquee, or the footer. Import them. Polish them. Move on."

What this phase does

Some pieces of every website are **solved problems**. A nice contact form. A scrolling logo marquee. A pricing table that doesn't look like a spreadsheet. You don't need Claude to build these from scratch. You import them from a registry, paste them into your project, and ask Claude to restyle them to match your site.

This is the step that makes a *"good"* site look like a *"premium"* site without adding hours of work.

Why this saves your sanity

Form validation, accessibility, mobile keyboard handling, edge cases.

These take days to get right from scratch. The components below have been polished by hundreds of designers already. Use them.

WHAT YOU'LL NEED BEFORE STARTING

- Your site from Phase 4 working in localhost.
- 30 minutes.

The steps

Components aren't templates to paste in unchanged — think of them as **references**. You can grab the bits you love (a button glow, a header animation, a footer pattern) and **remix them**. Claude is happy to take an effect from one component and apply it somewhere else.

1. **Open 21st.dev** at 21st.dev. Browse the registry — it's a library of ready-made pieces: contact forms, scrolling logo strips, footers, pricing tables, animated buttons, hover effects. Look for the ones *you like the feel of*.
2. **Copy the component prompt** for each one you want. Every piece on 21st.dev has a copy button that grabs a block of text describing it in full — ready to hand to Claude.
3. **Paste it into Claude with a natural sentence** — like: *"Let's use this card for the 'How we work' section."* Or: *"Drop this footer at the bottom and restyle it to match the rest of the site."* No special syntax. Claude reads the prompt and places the piece where you said.
4. **The preview refreshes**. The new pieces should now look like they were always part of your site.
5. **Remix freely**. If you saw a button glow you loved on one component, just tell Claude: *"take that glow effect and apply it to the main button on the hero too."* You're feeding Claude inspiration, not locking yourself into one template.

Phase 6 — Deploy

"Your site is done. One conversation and it's online, at a real URL, for free."

What this phase does

Up to now your site has only existed **on your own computer**. To share it — with a client, a friend, the world — it needs to live on the public internet. The good news: there's a free service made exactly for this, and **Claude handles most of the wiring**. You don't need to learn what a server is, or how to upload anything. You just sign up to one site and click "yes" a couple of times.

WHAT YOU'LL NEED BEFORE STARTING

- A free Vercel account (vercel.com).
- The site you built in Phase 4 working on your computer.
- 5 minutes.

The steps

1. Sign up at vercel.com — free, no card needed.
2. Back in Claude, ask: "deploy this site to Vercel for me." Claude handles all the technical setup — you just click "yes" on Vercel a couple of times when it asks for permission.
3. A live URL appears — something like `your-site.vercel.app`. Open it. Share it. It's online.

tip

every time you tweak something later, just say "redploy" in Claude and Vercel updates the live site automatically. no manual uploads, ever.

That's the workflow.

One file came with this PDF in the bundle you downloaded:

1. A `CLAUDE.md` config file you can drop into the root of any Claude project. It biases Claude toward premium output: motion-first, video heroes, clean typography, no template feel.

I hope this helps you turn the ideas you've been carrying around into something real.

Let me know what you think — this guide stays free, and keeps getting sharper.

— Luke

P.S. A masterclass is in the works. It goes much deeper into *art direction, branding, typography, 3D, motion, strategy* — and much more. DM me **CLASS** on Instagram to join the first wave and lock in 30% off (from \$29 to \$19).

Plain-English glossary

If a term in this guide tripped you up, look here.

TERM	WHAT IT MEANS IN PLAIN ENGLISH
Hero section	The big visual area at the top of a website. The first thing visitors see.
Reference (folder)	The collection of sites and images you save before designing, so your site has a clear taste direction instead of looking AI-generic.
Prompt	The exact words you type to Claude (or any AI) to ask it to do something.
Skill	A small add-on you install in Claude that gives it specific knowledge or opinions.
Library / dependency	Pre-written code other people made that you can include in your project. Motion is a library for animations.
Component	A pre-built piece of a website (like a form or a footer) that you import instead of building from scratch.
Registry	A website like 21st.dev where you browse and copy components.
Easing	The speed curve of an animation — how it accelerates and slows down. "Smoother easing" means a gentler, less abrupt motion.
Localhost	Your website running on your own computer, only visible to you, before you put it online.
Deploy	The act of putting your finished website online so others can visit it.
Mobile-friendly	Looks good on phones, tablets, and computers without breaking.

Build something **premium** this week.

This is a curated primer — I keep refining it as the workflow gets sharper. **Every update is free**, and lands in your inbox automatically.

The masterclass goes deep into *art direction, branding, typography, 3D, motion, strategy* — and much more. Built so anyone can follow it.

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